CLIMATE FUND BILL CLEARS BOTH CHAMBERS; GOVERNOR NON-COMMITTAL

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ARDENPORT — The Climate Resilience Funding Act passed the House late Thursday by 70 votes to 40, more than three months after clearing the Senate 25 to 22. The bill now goes to the Governor, who has ten days.

The Act would establish a dedicated fund for coastal and flood resilience, paid for by charges on large sellers of fossil fuel products and by fees on the purchase and renovation of higher-value property in designated zones.

Asked after the vote whether he would sign, the Governor said he had asked the Attorney General for advice and would say nothing until he had it. “I am not going to sign a bill that will be struck down in eighteen months,” he said. “And I am not going to veto one that will hold.”

The bill’s Senate sponsor said the vote reflected three years of storm damage. The House minority leader said the measure would be in court before it raised a dollar.

Industry reaction was immediate. The Arden Petroleum Council said it was “weighing all options”. A spokesman for one of the larger out-of-state sellers said the company had not yet determined whether it would even be covered by the Act, a remark several members said they did not understand.

Additional reporting from the State House bureau.